

FNB APP ACADEMY · FROM GRASSROOTS TO GREATNESS

FACILITATION DECK

Module 1: Digital Literacy & Productivity Tools

Building the digital foundations that underpin every module in this programme.

Duration: Approximately 4 hours

Format: Facilitated lecture



Module 1 at a glance

01	Foundations of Digital Literacy: The Triad Model Digital, data & AI literacy, and how they build on each other	~50 min
02	Introduction to AI: Concepts, Capabilities & Critical Limitations Building a mental model for using AI critically and confidently	~50 min
03	Building Your Second Brain: CODE, PARA & Productivity Tools A system to capture, organise and use everything that matters	~50 min
04	Safety, Data & Your Digital Footprint: POPIA & Algorithmic Awareness Your legal obligations and building a footprint that works for you	~50 min

By the end of this module, you will be able to

- Define digital literacy and explain its role as the foundation for data and AI literacy, using the Triad Model
- Build a mental model of AI: how it works, where it fails, and how to engage it with critical awareness
- Apply the CODE method to capture, organise, distil and express knowledge to build a Second Brain
- Construct a personal Second Brain using the PARA framework, with Notion as your primary platform
- Recognise your digital footprint, understand data rights and identify your POPIA obligations as an entrepreneur

Foundations of Digital Literacy: The Triad Model

Digital literacy is not a destination - it's the foundation that every other skill in this programme is built on.

Duration: ~50 minutes · Knowledge check at the end

01

Learning objectives

- Define digital literacy and explain its role as the foundational prerequisite for data and AI literacy
- Describe the five competence areas of the DigComp 2.2 framework and apply them to your business context
- Explain the Triad Model and the three dimensions that run through all three literacy types
- Distinguish between "technology utilisation" and "technology orchestration" and identify which stage you are in

Two entrepreneurs, same product, same township — very different outcomes

ENTREPRENEUR A

Uses WhatsApp to chat with customers. Digitally literate in the everyday sense but stuck at basic use.

ENTREPRENEUR B

Uses WhatsApp **Business** to catalogue products, auto-respond, display hours, and accept payment. Leveraging tools to scale.

23%

of South African entrepreneurs have sufficient digital capabilities for the modern economy — vs. **47%** globally. Not a talent gap. An access and training gap. (Mugunzva & Manchidi, 2025)



"Understanding how to leverage AI and big data is not optional anymore for entrepreneurs. It is becoming a baseline requirement for competitive advantage."

— DEVAAN PARBHOO, 2026

KEY IDEA

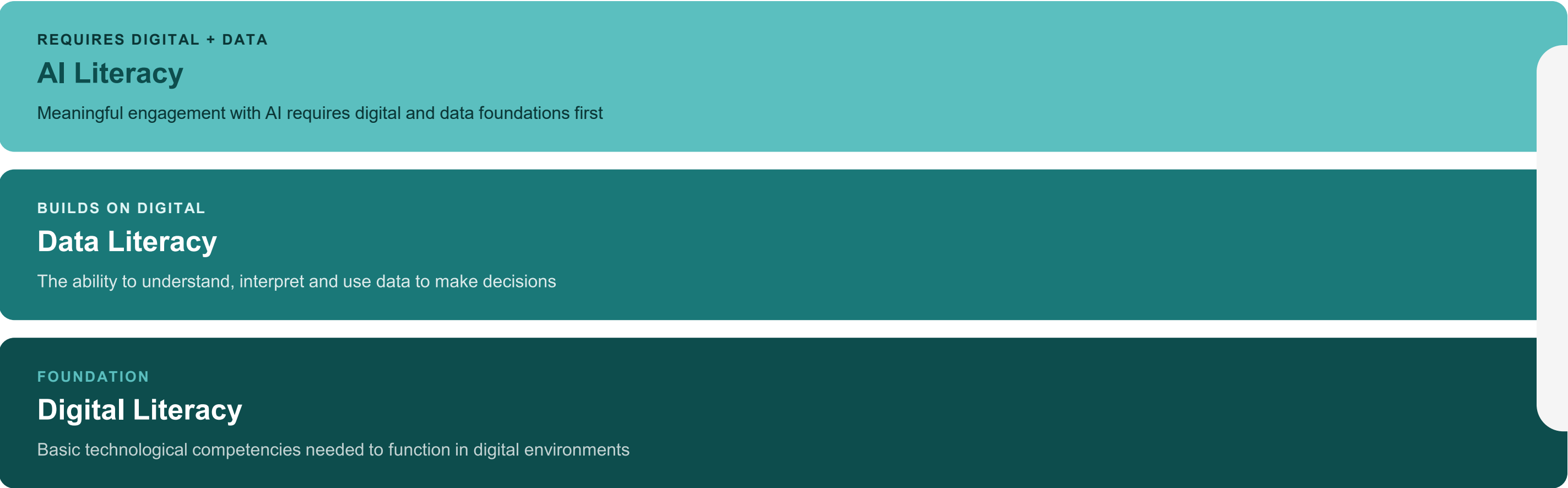
The most significant digital learning happens when people apply technologies to solve real entrepreneurial problems — not when they merely learn about them in the abstract.

The five DigComp 2.2 competence areas

COMPETENCE AREA	WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOUR BUSINESS
1. Information & Data Literacy	Finding, evaluating and using digital information and data to make business decisions
2. Communication & Collaboration	Using digital channels — WhatsApp Business, email, CRM — with customers, suppliers, partners
3. Digital Content Creation	Producing content — posts, product descriptions, promotional material — with tools like Canva, Notion, or AI
4. Safety	Protecting your personal and business data, your brand voice, and your customers' information
5. Problem-Solving	Using digital tools to solve business challenges creatively, rather than defaulting to manual approaches

Tip: None of these five areas requires a technology degree. All are learnable, practical skills.

The Triad Model



"Digital literacy is a foundational concept essential for understanding and engaging with both data and AI literacy."

— Polomoshnov, Masso & Lobanova, 2026

Three dimensions, every literacy type

Technical

Understanding how digital systems, data processes and AI tools actually work.

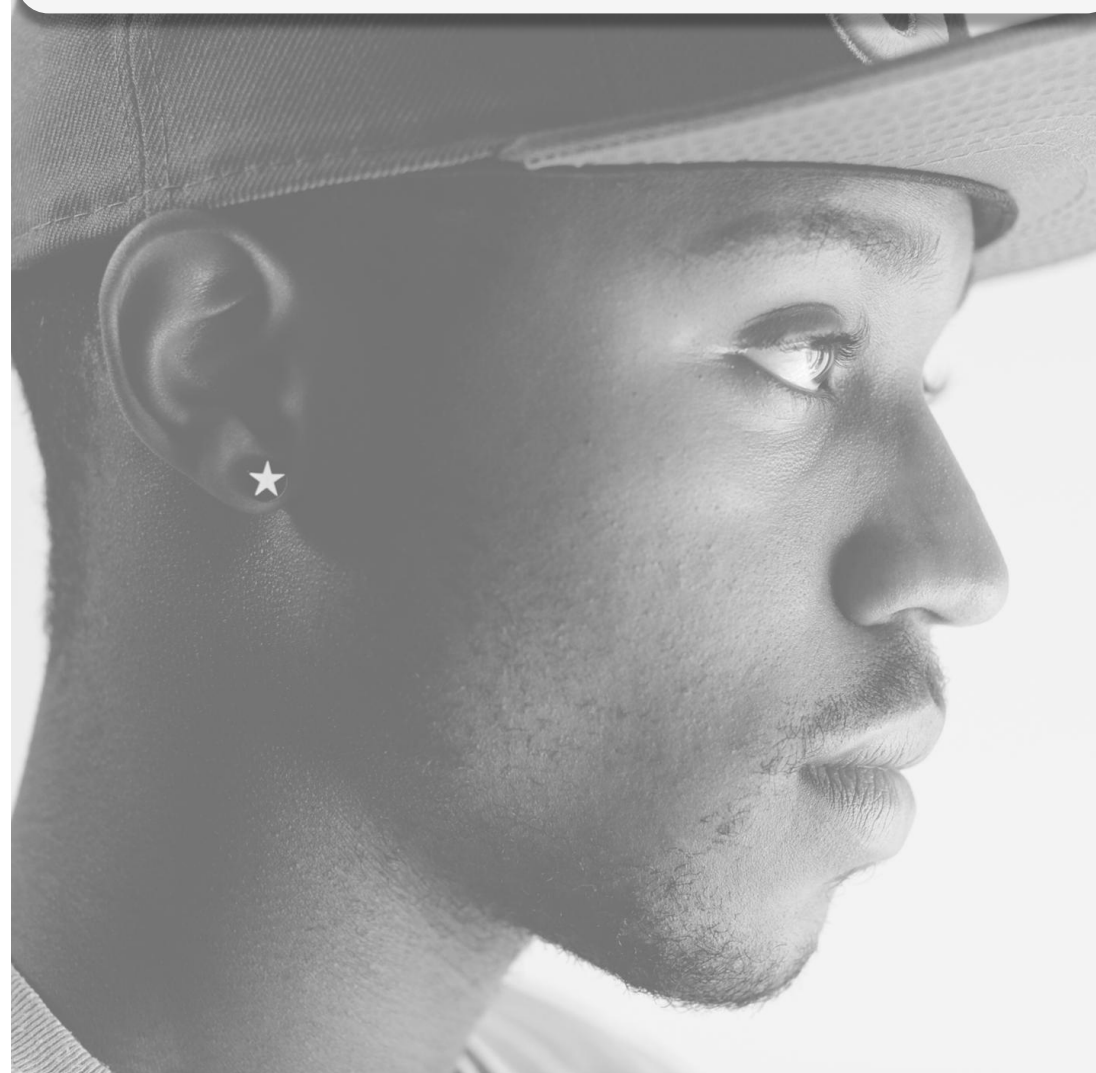
Helps you choose the right tools and understand their limitations



Critical Thinking

Approaching digital tools, data and AI with both trust and healthy scepticism

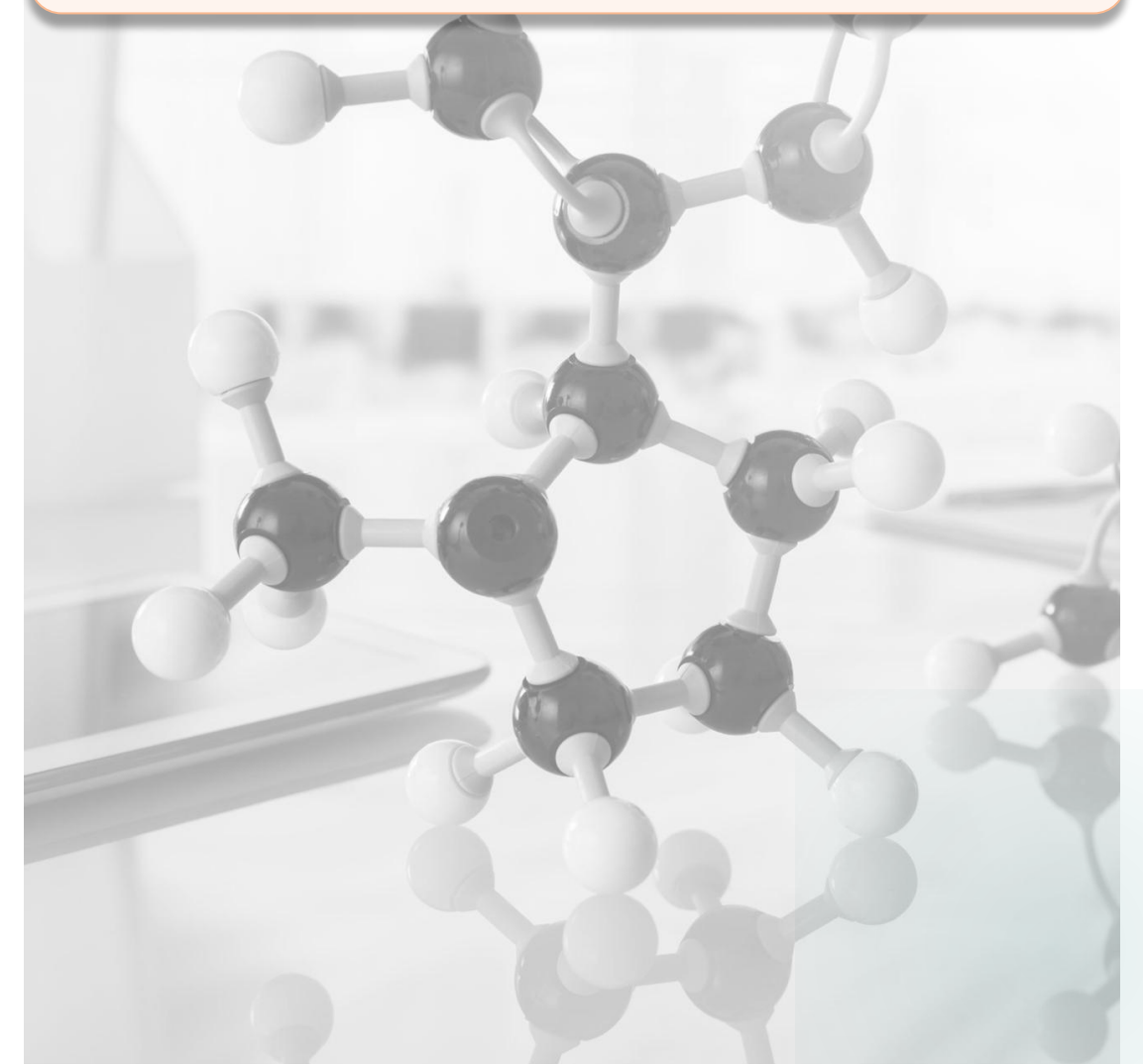
Prevents you from blindly following platform or AI recommendations



Communicative-Cognitive

Interpreting, integrating and communicating digital/AI content accurately and responsibly

Keeps you the author of your own judgment, not the systems you use



From utilisation to orchestration

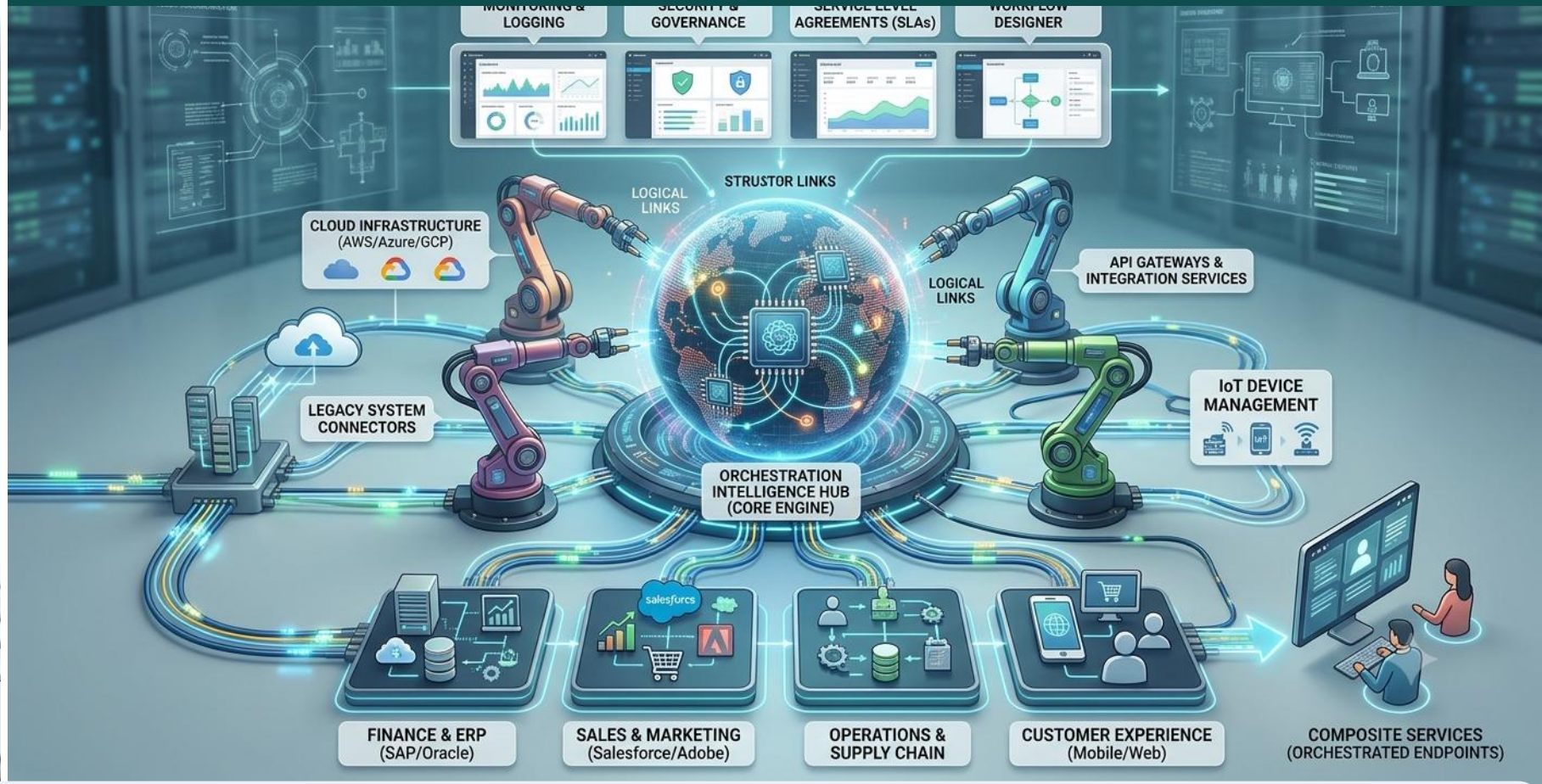
TECHNOLOGY UTILISATION

Using tools for what they were obviously designed to do — sending a message, scrolling, prompting an LLM. Where most people start, and many stay.



TECHNOLOGY ORCHESTRATION

→ Deploying tools strategically, in combination, to create business value that wouldn't exist otherwise. The competitive edge.



"Acquiring digital competencies follows a non-linear progression... learners exhibit distinctly different behaviour patterns, shifting from technology utilisation to technology orchestration." — Mugunzva & Manchidi, 2025

Solo entrepreneurs who orchestrate their tools

Pieter Levels (Levels.io)

70+ products · \$3M+ annual revenue · solo

Notes → GitHub → automated deployment → Stripe → Twitter, all feeding into each other without manual intervention. He is the conductor, not the operator.

Justin Welsh

\$5M+ annual revenue · solo

Notion (content planning) → Typefully (scheduling) → ConvertKit (email, triggered) → Stan Store (sales).
Each tool feeds the next; the system compounds effort.

The orchestration — not any single tool — is what separates these entrepreneurs from someone who simply "posts occasionally."

**“I made \$8M
with no
employees”**



The opportunity in the gap

South Africa's digital literacy gap is real: unequal internet access, limited contextualised training, education systems that haven't kept pace. But once entrepreneurs receive structured, contextualised learning, capability development is **rapid and non-linear**.

"You are not behind; you are early. The entrepreneurs who build genuine digital capability now are positioning themselves ahead of the market, not catching up to it."

Pause and consider

1. Which of the five DigComp 2.2 competence areas feels strongest in your business right now? Which is weakest?
2. Where would you honestly place yourself between "utilisation" and "orchestration"? What's holding you there?
3. Looking at the Triad Model, where is your strongest literacy — and your biggest gap?

Portia Dlamini: Cape Town caterer

When the pandemic hit in 2020, Portia's catering bookings disappeared overnight, no website, no social presence, no digital payments.

What changed wasn't just her tools, it was her relationship with technology. She moved from utilisation to orchestration, and her revenue reflected it.

She started with WhatsApp Business, then a Facebook Business Page, then a SnapScan QR code on her packaging. Within six months, **40% of her bookings** came from Facebook, customers she'd never met in person.

DISCUSS & PONDER

Which DigComp 2.2 areas did Portia develop? What was her threshold moment?

Key takeaways

- Digital literacy spans five DigComp 2.2 areas. Not just knowing how to use a smartphone
- The Triad Model: digital literacy is the foundation for data literacy, which is the foundation for AI literacy
- The critical shift is from technology utilisation to technology orchestration
- Technical, critical-thinking and communicative-cognitive dimensions apply across every literacy in this programme
- Only 23% of SA entrepreneurs have sufficient digital capability today, that's an opportunity, not a ceiling

Introduction to AI: Concepts, Capabilities & Critical Limitations

AI is not magic and not a replacement for your thinking, it's a powerful tool that works only as well as your understanding of it.

Duration: ~50 minutes · Knowledge check at the end

02

Learning objectives

- Explain in plain language how large language models generate outputs
- Build a mental model of AI that includes its capabilities, limitations, and failure modes
- Apply the three dimensions of AI literacy to evaluate AI outputs in your business
- Identify and counter five common misconceptions about AI
- Explain how AI functions as a capacity equaliser for South African entrepreneurs

Using AI and understanding AI are two very different things

You have probably already used AI. Drafting a quote in ChatGPT, asking Meta AI a question on WhatsApp, reading an AI summary at the top of a Google search.

But when you don't understand how AI works, you're more likely to trust it when you shouldn't, to miss when it's wrong, and to miss the ways it could genuinely transform your business.

KEY IDEA

Before you touch any AI tool, build the right mental model. The technical, critical, and communicative-cognitive dimensions matter more than which tool you use.

Prediction, not understanding

Large language models are trained on enormous amounts of text. They learn statistical patterns, which words tend to follow which other words, in which contexts.

When you type a question, the model is not "thinking" the way a human does; it is *predicting*: given this prompt, what is the most probable next word? And the word after that?

Mental model: Think of AI like an extremely well-read person who has read almost everything ever written but never experienced the real world. They can write about anything but can't verify what's currently true.

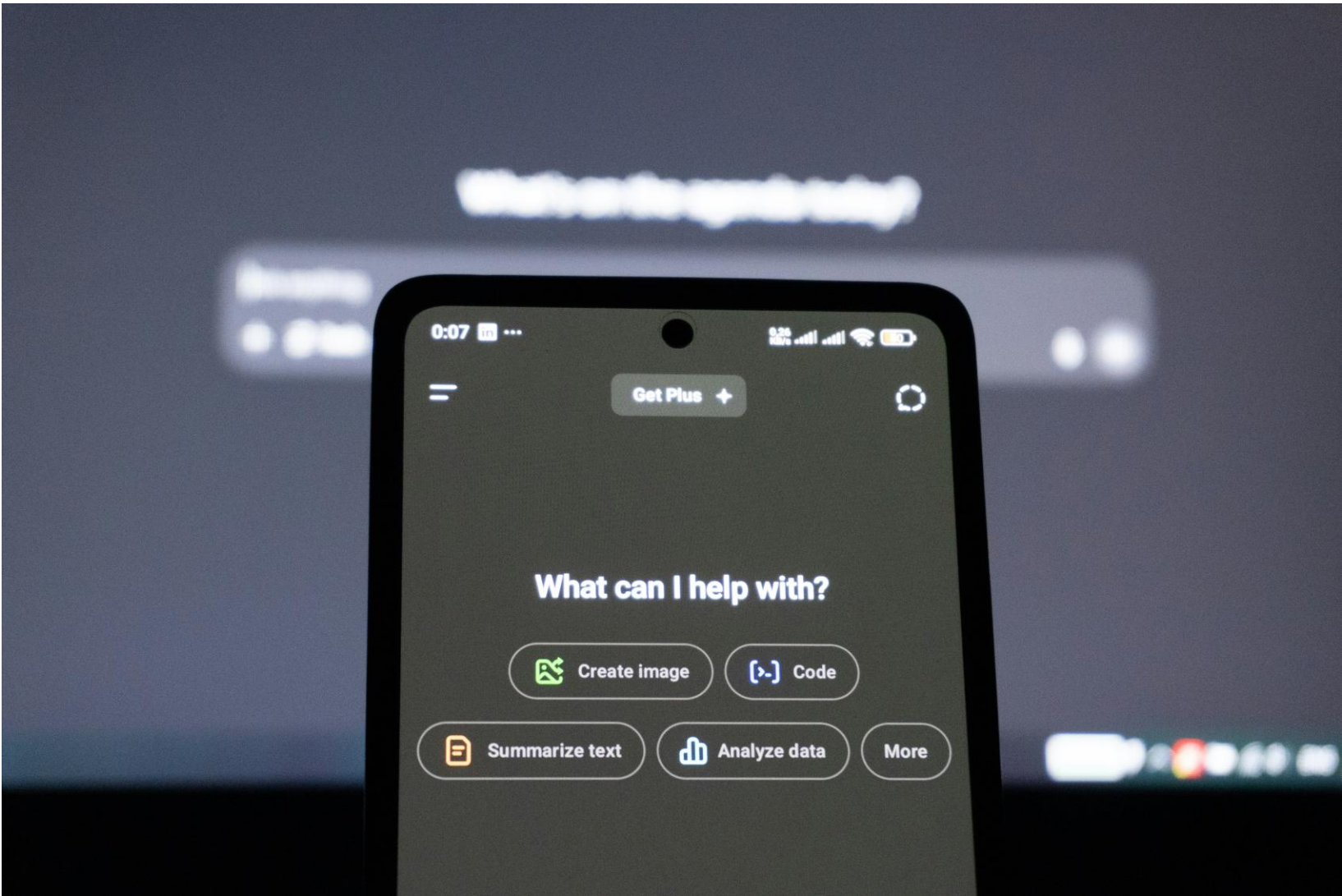
Because it pattern-matches rather than retrieves live information, AI can:

Produce confident but factually wrong statements

Invent citations, stats, and names that sound real

Present outdated info as current, or reflect training biases

A genuine equaliser for small business tasks



Text generation & drafting

Product descriptions, WhatsApp auto-replies, proposals

Translation & simplification

Between SA languages; simplifying legal/financial documents

Editing & improving

Clarity and professionalism of text you've already written

Research & summarisation

Summarising documents, explaining complex topics simply

Brainstorming & ideation

Business names, marketing angles, FAQs, product features

Answering business questions

Plain-language explanations of tax, marketing, business concepts

Plus: code, ideate, and design — building ideas from natural language using code and a pre-defined design system.

Misconceptions 1 & 2

MISCONCEPTION 1

"AI is like a search engine." Search engines retrieve existing pages; AI generates new text by prediction. It does not look up answers, it constructs them. Always verify facts and citations that matter for business decisions.

MISCONCEPTION 2

"If AI said it, it must be correct." AI makes mistakes and invents citations, not a bug to be fixed, but inherent to how language models work. Critical evaluation of every output is the most important AI skill you can develop.

Misconceptions 3 & 4

MISCONCEPTION 3

"AI will replace my expertise." AI is a force-multiplier for capable operators. The more you know about your business, the better you can evaluate, direct, and use AI outputs. Without your expertise, AI output is unfiltered and unvalidated.

MISCONCEPTION 4

"AI is a person, it understands me." AI produces text that sounds empathetic, but it experiences none of it. Anthropomorphising AI leads to over-reliance and less critical evaluation of its outputs.

Misconception 5

"AI IS NEUTRAL AND OBJECTIVE."

Every AI system reflects the values, priorities, and biases embedded in its training data and the choices of its developers. AI trained primarily on English-language Western content will have gaps and biases when applied to South African business contexts. Recognising this is the beginning of responsible use.

All five misconceptions share one antidote: critical evaluation, every time.

Trust it, question it, communicate it responsibly

Technical: Understanding that AI predicts rather than retrieves, that it can fabricate confidently, and that its knowledge has a cutoff date.

Critical thinking: Productive trust plus healthy scepticism — verifying outputs, cross-checking facts, keeping your own judgment.

Communicative-cognitive: Interpreting and communicating AI content correctly — recognising mistakes or bias, integrating output responsibly.

"It is not sufficient to focus solely on how to formulate requests correctly... [it must include] a technical dimension, a critical thinking dimension, a communicative-cognitive dimension." — Polomoshnov, Masso & Lobanova, 2026

Access to a copywriter, translator, coach and researcher — at zero marginal cost

A large corporation can afford specialists in each of these areas. An emerging entrepreneur cannot. AI closes that gap, meaningfully and immediately, with the critical awareness you're building today.



PRIMARY TOOLS FOR SA ENTREPRENEURS

Meta AI: in WhatsApp. Free, data-light.

ChatGPT: chat.openai.com or free app.

Claude: claude.ai.

Google Gemini: gemini.google.com.

Pause and consider

1. Which of the five AI misconceptions are you most guilty of? What would change if you corrected it?
2. Which "what AI can do" category would save you the most time in your business?
3. What's the first business task you'd like to try with AI this week? What would you need to verify?

CASE STUDY

Sipho Mthembu — Soweto e-commerce entrepreneur

Sipho sold handmade leather goods, spending 4-5 hours a week writing product descriptions and posts by hand. A friend recommended ChatGPT.

He copied a generated description straight into his store, and discovered two days later the AI had invented a detail about the leather that didn't match his actual product.

He didn't abandon AI, he built a practice: draft with AI, read critically, correct fabrications, publish. His writing time dropped from **5 hours to 90 minutes** a week.

DISCUSS

Which AI literacy dimension did Sipho's experience illustrate? What habits could catch AI errors before they reach your customers?

Key takeaways

- AI predicts the next most probable word, it does not retrieve verified facts
- Five misconceptions to correct: search engine, infallible, replaces expertise, is a person, is neutral
- Technical, critical-thinking and communicative-cognitive dimensions apply to every AI interaction
- AI is a capacity equalizer, access to professional-grade output at zero marginal cost

Building Your Second Brain: CODE, PARA & Productivity Tools

A simple, powerful system to capture everything important, organise it intelligently, and use it when it matters most.

Duration: ~50 minutes · Knowledge check at the end

03

Learning objectives

- Explain the purpose and philosophy of a Second Brain and why it matters for entrepreneurs
- Apply the CODE method (Capture, Organise, Distil, Express) to manage business information
- Set up a basic PARA structure (Projects, Areas, Resources, Archives) in Notion
- Identify practical use cases for Notion, Trello, and NotebookLM
- Recognise the threshold moment — the shift from reactive to intentional knowledge management

A great idea lost within 24 hours is not a discipline problem — it's a systems problem

How many tabs do you have open right now? How many starred WhatsApp messages have you never returned to? How many voice notes to yourself are still unlistened?

Your biological brain is extraordinary at generating and connecting ideas — it was never designed to reliably store them. For entrepreneurs who are simultaneously CEO, sales, product and customer service, this loss has real business consequences.

"The transformation from passive consumer to active digital entrepreneur requires not just access to tools, but the development of systematic approaches to how those tools are used to create value."

— Mugunzva & Manchidi, 2025

A trusted external system for everything that matters

A Second Brain is a digital tool, typically Notion, where you capture, organise, and retrieve everything that matters to your business and life. Not a filing system: an active, living repository.

The concept comes from Tiago Forte's *Building a Second Brain* (2022). His core insight: most entrepreneurs don't have a knowledge problem — they have a **retrieval problem**. The information exists; it's just stored nowhere useful.

A Second Brain is "personal knowledge management": a digital extension of your memory you can search, update, and draw from at any moment.



Capture · Organise · Distil · Express

C

Capture

Save what resonates — not everything. Web Clipper, voice notes, screenshots.

O

Organise

Sort by actionability, not topic. Which PARA category does this belong to?

D

Distil

Extract the essential insight. Highlight it so future-you can scan quickly.

E

Express

Turn knowledge into output: a proposal, a post, a client email.

Tip: If you're genuinely excited or surprised by something, it's worth saving. If you're mildly interested but think you "should" keep it, you probably won't use it — skip it.

Where everything lives

P — Projects

Active goals with a finish line. "Launch new menu," "Apply for SEDA funding."

R — Resources

Topics to return to. "Digital marketing tips," "POPIA compliance notes."

A — Areas

Ongoing responsibilities, no end date. "Financial records," "Staff management."

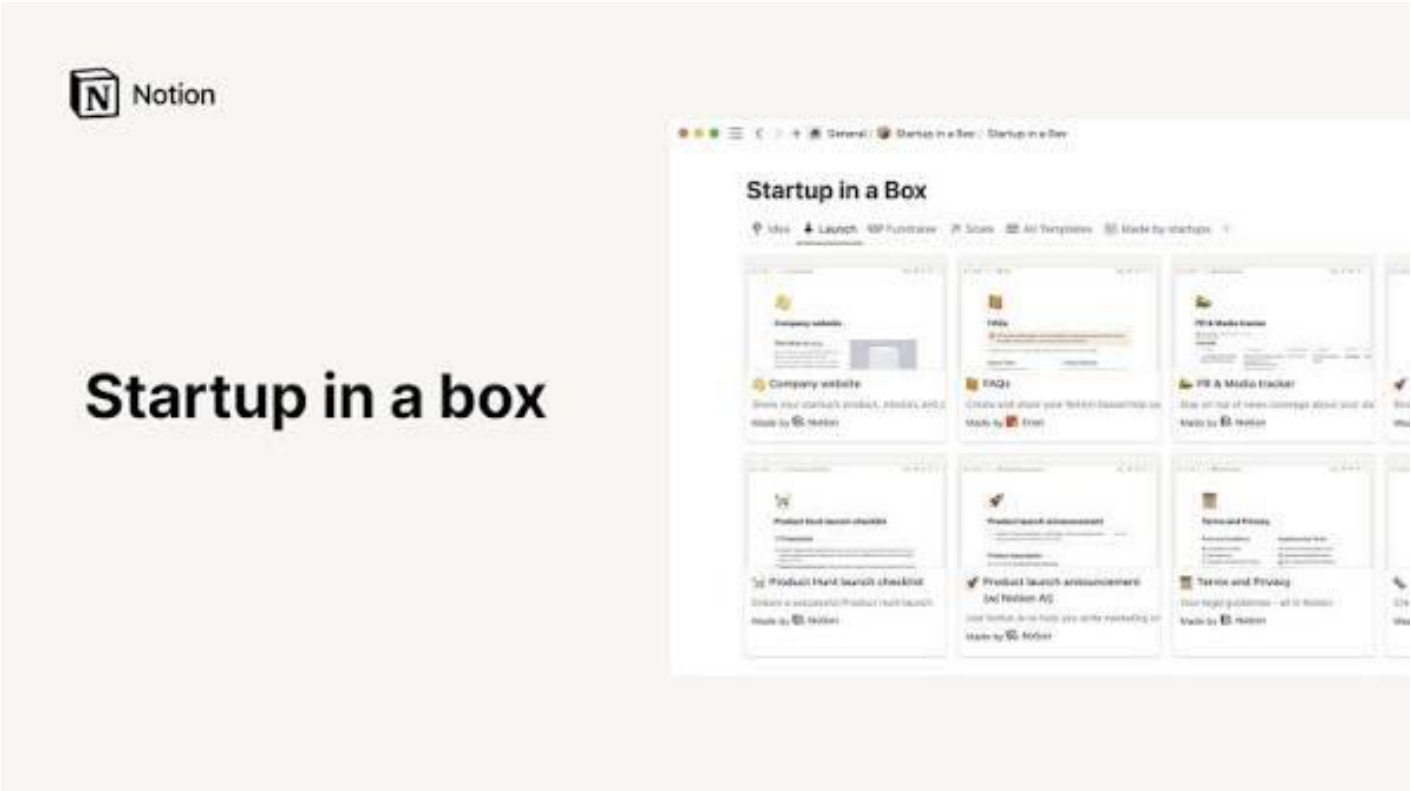
A — Archives

Completed / inactive — moved out of view, not deleted.

Note: Keep it simple. If you can't remember which folder something lives in, you have too many folders. When in doubt, put it in Archives — not a new category.

Free, flexible, and built for PARA

Pages & Sub-pages	Build PARA as four top-level pages with sub-pages for specific projects
Databases	Track clients, suppliers, inventory, or content calendars, structured, searchable
Templates	Free built-in templates for notes, planning, and weekly reviews
Notion AI	Summarise notes, draft emails from bullet points, generate first drafts
Web Clipper	Save articles and web pages to your Second Brain in one click



Trello for tasks, NotebookLM for research

Trello — task management

Visual, card-based boards for managing tasks — especially once you start working with a team. Columns like "To Do," "In Progress," "Done"; each task is a card that moves through them.

NotebookLM — research synthesis

Free from Google. Upload documents and have an AI conversation with them — it responds only from what you uploaded, far less likely to fabricate than ChatGPT.



Tip: Notion first, always. Trello joins once you have collaborators to coordinate with.

From reactive to intentional

BEFORE THE THRESHOLD

Information everywhere, findable nowhere. Ideas lost. Documents unfindable under pressure. Constant, low-level overwhelm.



AFTER THE THRESHOLD

Everything important lives somewhere trusted and retrievable. Decisions get faster. Creative output increases.

The threshold moment is not when you download Notion. It's when you first find something you captured weeks ago, exactly when you need it.

REFLECTION · TAKE A MOMENT

Pause and consider

1. Where does most of your important business information live right now? Is it accessible under pressure?
2. Which of the four PARA categories feels most chaotic in your business right now?
3. What is the one piece of knowledge you most want to capture and never lose again?

CASE STUDY

Nomsa Sithole — Durban freelance designer

Nomsa managed 12 active clients and four projects held together by email, WhatsApp, and a note app she rarely updated.

One Saturday, she built a Notion workspace with a PARA structure — a project page per client, a resource library, archives for completed work.

She stopped missing deadlines and sending files to the wrong clients. Her client renewal rate improved — not because her design skills changed, but because her **reliability** became visible. Now she runs a 20-minute weekly review every Friday.

DISCUSS

Which PARA categories helped Nomsa most? When could you carve out your own "Saturday setup" this week?

Key takeaways

- A Second Brain solves a retrieval problem, not a knowledge problem
- CODE: Capture what resonates, Organise by actionability, Distil the insight, Express it as output
- PARA gives every piece of information a home: Projects, Areas, Resources, Archives
- Notion is your Second Brain; Trello joins for team task management; NotebookLM for document research

Safety, Data & Your Digital Footprint: POPIA & Algorithmic Awareness

Understanding what you're creating, what you're legally obligated to protect, and how to build a digital presence that works for you.

Duration: ~50 minutes · Knowledge check at the end

04

Learning objectives

- Explain what data is, how it's created, and why it matters for business decisions
- Describe how algorithms affect your business visibility and customer reach
- Identify your legal obligations under POPIA
- Distinguish a passive digital footprint from an intentional one
- Apply at least three practical digital safety practices in your business

Every SnapScan payment, every WhatsApp reply, every click — that's data

The opportunity: data helps you make better decisions, what's working, who your customers are, when demand peaks.

The obligation: if you collect any customer information, you operate under the Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA), South Africa's primary data protection law.

"Decisions based on data and evidence tend to be more successful and trustworthy... people are more conscious of the data they consciously or unconsciously create, share, and use."

— Polomoshnov, Masso & Lobanova, 2026

Any recorded piece of information about your business

Customer names, numbers, emails, delivery addresses

Transaction records: what, when, for how much, to whom

Engagement data: views, clicks, opens

Behavioural data: purchase timing, discovery path

Operational data: stock levels, supplier lead times, delivery rates

Ask: "What does the data tell me?" — about your posts, your sales, your customers. WhatsApp Business and social apps offer free analytics — start there.

How platforms shape your business visibility

Social media algorithms Determine which customers see your content. Early engagement gets amplified.

Search algorithms Determine whether you appear when customers search. Local SEO matters directly.

Recommendation systems TikTok/Instagram/YouTube shape which trends and products your customers see.

AI-driven advertising A poorly targeted ad wastes money; a well-targeted one reaches the right buyers.

Predictive compliance

Users pre-emptively adjust behaviour based on anticipated system feedback, without being explicitly told to. Notice specific images get more likes, so you start only posting that type even if it doesn't fully represent your business.

KEY IDEA

The goal is not to beat the algorithm. It's to remain the author of your own business decisions.

Protection of Personal Information Act

POPIA came into full effect in 2021. It regulates how anyone collects, stores, uses and shares personal information. It applies to you if you:

- Maintain a customer contact list, on your phone or in a spreadsheet
- Run a WhatsApp Business account with saved customer conversations
- Collect names or emails via an order form, website or Google Form
- Run paid social advertising targeting people based on their data
- Store customer payment details or copies of ID documents

POPIA principles, in practice

PRINCIPLE	WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOUR BUSINESS
Accountability	You're responsible for protecting information — even if a supplier holds it for you
Processing limitation	Collect only what you actually need for a clear purpose
Purpose specification	Be clear why you're collecting information; only use it for that purpose
Information quality	Keep records accurate and current; remove old or incorrect entries
Openness	Tell customers what you hold, why, and how they can ask for removal
Security safeguards	Protect information — strong passwords, secure storage, controlled access
Data subject participation	Customers can ask what you hold and request corrections or deletion

Starter: "We collect your name and contact number to process orders and communicate with you. We do not share your information with third parties. Reply STOP to be removed."

Passive footprint vs. intentional footprint

PASSIVE

Built by platforms and algorithms based on activity — fragmented, inconsistent, controlled by the platform, not you.

INTENTIONAL — STARTS WITH

- A complete, verified Google Business Profile
- Consistent name, logo, description across platforms
- Regular, purposeful content
- Proactive review management
- A website/landing page you own

Note: Platform accounts are rented space — you don't own your followers. An owned contact list or email database is a far more secure long-term asset.

Pause and consider

1. What customer data does your business currently collect? Where is it stored, and who has access?
2. If a customer asked "what personal information do you hold about me?" right now, could you answer confidently?
3. Is your digital footprint something you built intentionally, or something that happened to you?

CASE STUDY

Thabo Mokoena — Pretoria clothing retailer

Thabo collected 800+ customer names and emails via a Google Form, many had never explicitly consented to marketing.

When a customer asked what data he held and to delete it, he didn't know how to answer. He added a Privacy Notice, sent an opt-in confirmation, and lost **30% of his list**.

The 70% who stayed were genuinely engaged. Open rates improved. Thabo now sees POPIA compliance as a filter for real customers, not a burden.

DISCUSS

Which POPIA principles did Thabo's original approach violate? What does this tell you about data responsibility and customer trust?

Key takeaways

- Every transaction, click, and message your business generates is data, asked of it: "what does this tell me?"
- Algorithms shape your visibility; higher digital literacy means lower "algorithmic subjection"
- POPIA applies to any entrepreneur collecting customer information, accountability starts with you
- Build an intentional digital footprint, don't just inherit a passive one

Four sub-modules, one journey

01 · FOUNDATIONS OF DIGITAL LITERACY

Digital literacy is the base of the Triad Model; the shift from utilisation to orchestration is the competitive edge.

02 · INTRODUCTION TO AI

AI predicts, it doesn't retrieve. Critical evaluation — technical, critical, communicative-cognitive — is the core skill.

03 · BUILDING YOUR SECOND BRAIN

CODE captures and processes knowledge; PARA organises it. Notion is your platform, Trello and NotebookLM support it.

04 · SAFETY, DATA & YOUR FOOTPRINT

Data is an asset and a responsibility. POPIA sets your obligations; an intentional footprint is your long-term advantage.

Everything that follows in this programme — building a digital business presence, using AI for customer communication and content — depends on the foundations you've built today.

BEFORE YOU GO

Commit to three specific actions in your business

Turn to your Learner Guide's Action Plan. Be specific, vague intentions rarely become completed tasks. Consider one action from each area:

A digital tool or habit you'll adopt this week

One PARA structure you'll set up in Notion

One POPIA action you'll take with customer data

FROM GRASSROOTS TO GREATNESS

Thank you

Your Learner Guide has the exercises, case studies and knowledge checks for each sub-module — work through them before Module 2.

